

century: his father, Johann Ambrosius, was a talented string player prominent in Eisenach's small-town musical life; several uncles were organists; and a cousin, Johann Christoph Bach, had achieved some renown as a composer.

Johann Sebastian learned to play and compose early in life, immersed in his family's rich musical tradition as well as its Lutheran Protestantism. He was orphaned at the age of nine, his father dying nine months after his mother, and was sent to live with his eldest brother, Christoph, at nearby Ohrdurf. Christoph was an organist who had been a pupil of the celebrated composer Johann Pachelbel and Johann Sebastian's informal musical education was able to continue under his brother's gaze. It may have been at Ohrdurf that he first learned to play the organ, and he certainly sang in the church choir as, at the age of 15, his vocal ability won him a place at the prestigious Michaeliskirche school in Lüneburg, near Hamburg in northern Germany. There, his interest in the organ grew under the influence of composer Georg Böhm, the organist at Lüneburg's Johanniskirche.